



Benin



Benin stretches north from the west African coast. In 1990, Benin became one of the pioneers of African democratization, ending 17 years of one-party Marxist-Leninist rule.



GEOGRAPHY

Sandy coastal region. Numerous lagoons lie just behind the shoreline. Forested plateaus inland. Mountains in the northwest.



CLIMATE

Hot and humid in the south. Two rainy seasons. Hot, dusty *harmattan* winds blow during the December–February dry season.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

There are 42 different ethnic groups. The southern Fon have tended to dominate politics. Other major groups are the Adja and Yoruba. The northern Fulani follow a nomadic lifestyle. North–south tension is mainly due to the south being more developed. French culture, centered on Cotonou, is highly prized. Substantial differences in wealth reflect a strongly hierarchical society.



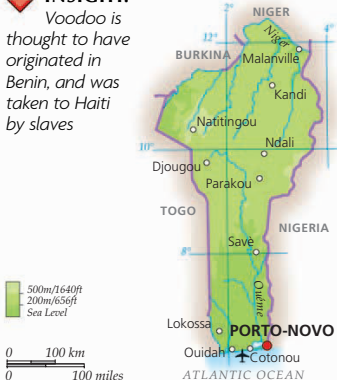
THE ECONOMY

Strong agricultural sector: cash crops include cotton, oil palm, and cashew nuts. Large-scale smuggling is a serious problem. France is the main aid donor.



INSIGHT:

Voodoo is thought to have originated in Benin, and was taken to Haiti by slaves



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Benin

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Porto-Novo

POPULATION: 8.94 million

TOTAL AREA: 43,483 sq. miles
(112,620 sq. km)

DENSITY: 209 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Fon, Bariba, Yoruba, Adja, Houeda, Somba, French*

RELIGIONS: 50%, Muslim 30%, Christian 20%

ETHNIC MIX: Fon 41%, other 21%, Adja 16%, Yoruba 12%, Bariba 10%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes